

er for Vista will be best utilised, whereas a video card that supports D3D9 but does not come with a WDDM driver will run on old-school GDI and will not offer any Vista special effects.

It is interesting to note that while Vista bundles along DirectX10, the interface itself is built upon Direct3D 9 (a part of DirectX 9). This was done since the development of the new window interface and DX10 happened in parallel and the team in charge of Windows Presentation Foundation did not wish to delay their work or build such an integral part of Windows on potentially unproven technology. The D3D9 under Vista is however, not the same version found under Windows XP—some new extensions needed to be added to the API to facilitate multiple applications to use D3D. This extended version is called Direct3D 9Ex. This is largely why Vista calls for a special driver version in order to support Aero: the driver offers Direct3D 9Ex support.

For hardware and software that supports the new Presentation Foundation, Vista will run a version of its interface termed Aero. Aero offers some rudimentary display features that leverage the new technology, namely, transparency effects to individual windows; transition effects to maximising and minimising windows; live thumbnails on the taskbar which track and immediately display any changes made to each window (for example, a new chat message under MSN would immediately show up in the chat window's thumbnail, even if the chat window is minimised). Aero also offers a new way to flip through open windows called Flip3D. If your video card is not DirectX 9.0 capable or if your card's manufacturer is still without a WDDM driver, Windows will run Windows Vista Basic on your computer—without all the effects mentioned above. Practically speaking, if your system has seen a video card update in the past three years, it should be able to run Windows Vista as it was meant to be run. Laptop owners might face issues, however, if their onboard video chip does not offer DX9 support.